DEBATER GUIDE TO PERSONAL GROWTH

Satiate your constant drive to learn, explore, and expand in new directions

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters to Debaters

The active minds and passion of Debaters can be tremendous assets in all of life's circumstances – and yet that same energy can get in their way. Personal growth involves using what works and either discarding what doesn't work or turning it into something useful. For Debaters, growth is often the interplay between engaging in their preferred spontaneous intellectual pursuits and succeeding in a world that doesn't always appreciate their style. Remaining true to themselves and developing their sense of self-worth while having the confidence to reach for a better self are the goals for those who wish to grow.

Nurturing and cherishing their passion for intellectual gymnastics are essential for people with this personality type. The full exercise of that passion often requires minding their own limits – as well as those of other people. Debaters sometimes allow their original thinking to place them in unconventional territory. If their novel ideas lead them too far away from what is conventionally useful or meaningful, they risk sabotaging their own success – especially if they push underconsidered notions, as they sometimes do. More practical people are often willing to dismiss Debaters' good ideas when they don't fit the time, place, or situation.

Although liking oneself and finding oneself worthy are important, those aspects cannot work alone – they are part of a feedback loop that includes action. Debaters need a plan, or at least a strong direction, to carry out their hopes for a satisfying life. Because they are idea people, planning and developing theoretical constructs come naturally to them,

but the help of other people is often a crucial element to executing their plans. Learning how that works in their lives while exploiting the value of their independent style is one of their challenges to creating an effective strategy for self-development. Fortunately, as Extraverts, Debaters have an impulse to interact with others – clearly an asset when one needs others for success.

Inner Strength

Improving interactions with the world is only one reason that dynamic, curious Debaters might pursue conscious self-development. It's true that expressing themselves, carrying their ideas to fruition, and accessing all possible advantages along the way is part of how people with this personality type achieve happiness and success. But there's an internal component to personal growth that's easily overlooked amid the drive to master the external world – and it's just as essential. Debaters often render critical appraisals of anyone's flaws and failings, including their own, and that carries some risk. Underneath their outward energy, stressors and negative attitudes can lurk, interfering with the pursuit of Debaters' grand goals – and their ultimate happiness.

Self-doubt and frustration are universal human experiences as well as areas where personal growth is highly beneficial. Debaters tend to rely on a vigorous, can-do approach to most situations and goals, with mixed results depending on the quality of their perceptions, knowledge, and skills. When something goes awry, it can provoke harsh internal responses that aren't easy to deal with. Part of Debaters' growth is working to develop and maintain an inner core of self-confidence that's based not necessarily on success but rather on self-awareness and self-acceptance. These personalities have a strong sense of rational objectivity, and that can help them avoid retreating into egotism or denial when things don't go their way. But they may instead resort to self-blame, which is hardly better. Excessive or harsh self-criticism saps Debaters' energy and motivation, making it that much harder for them to get back on their feet and do what needs to be done. However, when Debaters regard themselves positively as well as objectively, they unlock their full potential.

So as much as Debaters may be focused on their development in external contexts, their internal growth tends to create a secure foundation for all other advancement. Wit, creativity, and vibrance are powerful Debater virtues, but they can become hollow if not backed by the positive inner strength of self-understanding. Personal growth helps Debaters further develop the parts of their personality that bring them a sense of pride, as well as those that enable them to be more effective in life. Irascible and indomitable as they may sometimes be, Debaters are at their best when fueled by joy, and that starts within themselves.

Want to boost your understanding of the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? Learn more here.

Facets of Personal Growth

Exploring Possibility

By its very nature, personal growth isn't the "one size fits all" affair that some self-help books would indicate. Personal growth is about expanding beyond what's comfortable or reflexive to explore larger ways of dealing with and defining existence. When the time for growth is clear to individuals, they can start by establishing baselines of their current functions in the world, evaluating the efficiency of their behavior and whether it's satisfying or not. With an objective perspective, Debaters may find room for improvement, and they can try out new actions and attitudes to help accomplish it.

Not all personal growth needs to be the product of deliberate effort. Sometimes it emerges gently from subtle shifts caused by age and maturity, and sometimes life prompts growth through hard times and crises. Debaters possess a wonderful enthusiasm for active experimentation, and when they use it to manage their growth, life's inevitable changes are likely to be positive rather than random. As the old saying goes, "You're either getting better, or you're getting worse. There's no staying the same."

Focusing on the Here and Now

For Debaters, personal growth often involves applying their inquisitive engagement with the outer world in realistic ways. To progress in life, many individuals need an orientation tool to help them recognize the right way to go, a sort of map or landmark, as well as the mindset to walk that path once they find it. For Debaters, their enthusiasm for new and interesting paths may distract them from some of life's important landmarks, and personal growth starts with understanding their unique challenges in this regard.

People with this personality type can hardly wait to see what's next in life, often becoming lost in excitement rather than grounded where they are. They don't lack for willpower when something grips their imagination, but learning to maintain steady concentration is just as important. Without stopping to focus on the here and now, they may struggle to carry their grand ideas to fruition. Debaters are bold seekers of truth, and personal growth can help them to balance their tendencies, carefully dividing their energy between their chosen priorities and whatever wonder may be over the horizon.

Abundant Energy for Growth

Debaters possess a wonderful combination of open-minded rationality and ready willingness to experiment – a perfect combination of tools to create personal growth. Debaters seize and are seized by inspiration not merely because of a feeling, but because the lure of potential triggers an intellectual spark. Throughout their lives, they may respond to this calling by embracing academic or professional challenges or by engaging with other people. Although they don't often easily settle on a predetermined path, Debaters are nonetheless doers, acting to chase their ideas, hopes, and curiosity.

Personal growth expands on Debaters' outwardly focused energy by inviting them to also look at themselves and see their vast potential for self-improvement. It's more than a quest to understand themselves – it's the idea that conscious change can follow on the heels of awareness. Their naturally energetic approach to any challenge also drives them. Sometimes the greatest use of their powerful minds is to turn them inward, to use objectivity to build joyful respect for who they are and what they might become. Here, we'll discuss how Debaters can pursue personal growth, as well as certain areas of themselves that they may want to examine.

Motivation and Development

Debaters can consider personal growth in five closely related but distinct areas. The first three relate to internal development of self-regard, while the latter two are more about tactics to engage in a more fulfilling life.

Motivation:

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much Debaters like themselves. Accepting both their flaws and their strengths creates a base of internal appreciation that enables change motivated by desire instead of shame.
- **Self-respect** refers to their sense of worth. People with this personality type value rational creativity, and when they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are follows accordingly.

- **Self-confidence** is the energy source that moves Debaters forward in life. When external engagement affirms their belief in their abilities, they can keep moving forward.

Development:

- **Self-evolution** describes processes of conscious growth that Debaters take on to realize their potential. Knowing when to assess and expand themselves enhances their abilities and their happiness.
- **Self-responsibility** means taking charge of their lives by accepting accountability for what they can do to improve things. Being conscious of their behavior helps them create what they want, instead of being buffeted by fate.

Debaters who attend to all five core components are more likely to lead successful and fulfilling lives, but a lack in any of the areas is likely to become a source of persistent difficulty. Insightful by nature, Debaters often benefit from asking themselves whether they're approaching life in balanced ways. Regardless of where their journeys start, every step forward represents a new place, a success unto itself. Debaters can decide for themselves what brings them to a joyful life. It could be anything, from traditional success in the form of great careers or happy families, to lives as globe-trotting explorers who experience everything the world has to offer.

Moving Forward

Conscious personal growth is about more than feeling obligated to change – it also requires the wisdom to seek new ways to be happier and more successful, based on a personalized definition of success. This e-book's goal is to spur that drive with ideas, encouragement, and guidance on some likely problems along the way in the five areas mentioned above.

In the following sections, we'll first examine Debaters' characteristics in their beneficial form. Using these components in a "balanced" way helps them lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives. Then we'll describe "unbalanced" tendencies that can emerge. We will address departures from healthy, productive motivation strategies, and we'll explain some

adverse effects that Debaters may experience as a result. Finally, we'll discuss what may be done to improve or "rebalance" within each of the motivational components. We'll suggest exercises, reflection, and actions to aid Debaters in the process of personal growth and development.

Self-Esteem

It's surprisingly common for rational people to struggle reconciling their intellectual tendencies with the emotional parts of their brains. Yet Debaters who maintain a firm connection to their inner sense of harmony also create strength in the higher functions of their beings, which they can express outwardly. Being at war within inhibits creation of a happy and inspired life, but self-appreciation is a state from which all good things can grow.

Balanced Self-Esteem

The Strength of Inner Harmony

Debaters are inquisitive and observant, and one of the ways they create balanced self-esteem is by being conscious of their feelings and facing them head-on. People with this personality type understand the value of rationally examining things in detail and keeping an eye on their inner workings to stay objective about life. When they look at their feelings honestly, they can let go of negative self-perceptions and discover how their humanity underpins their intellectuality in wonderful ways.

The benefits of working toward balance aren't just internal, as self-esteem tends to manifest outwardly as competence. When Debaters feel happy with who they are inside, many potentially troublesome behaviors can be replaced with productive ones, thanks to that inner security. Those with positive self-esteem don't need to diminish others to prove themselves, for example, because they know that their worthiness stands on its own. It's as if inner harmony flows out to positively affect all areas of life, making self-esteem an important step in personal growth.

Loving Their Minds

Debaters also develop their sense of self-esteem based on how well they can use their agile minds to figure things out, as well as how adept they are at articulating and defending their ideas. They tend to draw connections quickly and think creatively. Over a lifetime, recognizing and practicing these qualities can build an ever-increasing appreciation of self. For a personality type that values intellectuality, being creative is the ultimate self-affirmation. This helps Debaters feel like "sources" of good things, in addition to having clever perceptions.

Because accomplishment and success typically start with an idea, Debaters' self-esteem logically follows on the heels of their sense of their ability to come up with and implement ideas. In their hearts, they feel good about the condition of their minds. When self-esteem is in balance, they don't need to base it on strict or traditional measures of success or comparison to others. Instead, it comes from an appreciation of their fertile imaginations, knowing they can use that power to make their lives better.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Dismissing Feelings

The desire to explore is among Debaters' virtues. However, they often dismiss things with which they're less comfortable, such as emotions (in themselves and others), in favor of what they consider to be more worthy pursuits. Such disregard for feelings can result in unbalanced self-esteem because it creates inherent dishonesty – the same seemingly arbitrary, messy, irrational states of feeling that Debaters may decry are also within them. Ignoring emotions to safeguard against their destructive elements can also leave untapped their virtuous sides, such as compassion, forgiveness, and esteem for self.

It's easy to understand why Debaters might seek self-regard through intellectuality rather than emotion: The latter can be confusing and daunting to confront, especially for a personality type that so respects and seeks to embody reason. However, those who deny the complete makeup of their being – both mind *and* heart – are avoiding reality. Without embracing the feelings that are part of the human experience,

Debaters cannot make peace with themselves, and their self-esteem may reach an eventual limit.

Relying on Argument

Debaters are aptly named for their ability to vibrantly communicate their opinions, but their expressions become unbalanced when they attempt to validate their self-esteem by dismissing the value of contrasting contributions. Debaters bolstered by such unbalanced exercise of intellectual ability may begin to believe only their press, placing their thoughts high above those of others, even despite contradictory evidence. Such ignorance, however unwitting, is pure poison for the intellectual capability that often defines Debaters' self-esteem.

If their self-regard is threatened – or simply underdeveloped – they may attack other views, preferring to feel powerful rather than practice respect or decorum. Bluster may win arguments at the cost of facts, but truly rational minds cannot tolerate such falsity without internal recrimination, even if they never show it on the outside. Any self-esteem Debaters build at the expense of a fair exchange with others is highly vulnerable if they should ever truly recognize such arbitrariness in themselves. For Debaters, truth and wisdom are too valuable to trade for a sense of intellectual superiority.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Embracing a Complete View of Self

Debaters can vitalize their self-esteem by accepting the presence of emotion instead of sweeping it aside. Becoming comfortable with the emotional side of themselves may take time, but Debaters can capitalize on the enthusiastic flexibility that often comes easily to them. A non-judgmental style is an asset when it comes to rebalancing self-esteem – when their emotions become a source of confusion, they can forgive themselves for simply being human.

Their tendency to engage intellectually rarely leads Debaters into vital internal challenges the way exploring their softer sides would. To help rebalance their connection with their emotions, a simple, direct approach may help them overcome any hesitation. A brief self-review

exercise is one way Debaters can learn to be OK with their everyday feelings and balance their self-esteem:

- When preparing for bed (brushing your teeth, etc.), take a moment to envision the following categories.
  - Unhappy self-regard
  - Happy self-regard
- Think back over the day and recall a moment of self-criticism, self-judgment, or self-doubt. Tag it as "unhappy self-regard."
- Do the same for a moment of fair satisfaction with yourself, and mentally tag it as "happy self-regard."
- Don't worry if there isn't an event to correspond to both categories. Just recall what's available and proceed.
- Rather than view these feelings as right or wrong, look at them as just part of the brain's function and, therefore, as much a part of the body as skin. For example, events can produce upset emotional responses in the brain, just as the stomach might become upset by bad food – it's a natural mechanism like any other, not a sign of a faulty system.
- Without self-judgment, consider how the events influenced the day. What helped or hindered personal goals, progress, and motivation? If there isn't a recallable event in one of the categories, why not? Is that a good thing?
- Take a moment to forgive any self-created negativity experienced during the day. It would be irrational to be upset if skin got goosebumps in response to being cold, so there's no need to feel bad about negative emotional responses, either. Just as you would make a conscious decision to move into a warmer room, decide to adjust your emotional state of mind.
- If this exercise reveals an appealing opportunity to do something differently, contemplate some constructive and optimistic ways to do so. That's a great way to end the review process before bed and set a positive goal for the next day.

Profound action isn't always required for Debaters to feel good about themselves, but regularly accessing their emotions in healthy ways may require deliberate effort. Luckily, the practice of positive feelings often starts to feel like a reward rather than an obligation.

Acknowledging Value and Merit

Instead of assuming their superiority, Debaters can consider worthy wisdom from others, even if it reshapes their views – a wonderful thing for anyone who really values truth and knowledge. Their pride can grow when they find correctness, and their intellectual strength can be demonstrated when they accept being corrected. Debaters create balanced self-esteem when they see their worth as based not only on what they know but also on their ability to learn and grow.

Debaters should also be aware that claiming intellectual triumph doesn't necessarily keep knowledge flowing – it's important to recognize when contrasting facts and opinions contribute to better understanding. People with this personality type can remind themselves that everything they know was once new information to them, and much of it was gained from others. Such realizations may help moderate any flashes of arrogance without harm to self-esteem. To help maintain pride in what they know without losing touch with what the world has yet to teach, they can practice the following:

- Pause whenever a new fact, experience, or conversation teaches something valuable.
- Consciously acknowledge the contribution and its benefits as coming from an outside source.
- When new information contradicts a personal belief, take a moment to think about what's more valuable: the ego boost from displaying knowledge, or the elevation of mind that comes from learning new things.
- Actively and outwardly express appreciation to any source of learning. If it's a book, give it a quick positive review online; if it's a person, thank them sincerely.

Self-esteem always comes into play when Debaters compare their mental output to others', but it doesn't need to be dependent on such comparisons. When they see how their ability to be flexible and absorb knowledge can affirm their mental capability, it creates happiness instead of conflict, as well as self-esteem that stands on a strong foundation.

Self-Respect

Debaters build self-respect when they live in accordance with their values and pursue their ideas. They're inquisitive by nature, so such things may be fluid, as the ongoing process of personal growth reveals new goals and ideas with which to experiment. Whatever shifts may happen, however, Debaters are happiest when they stay true to their underlying set of intellectual principles.

Balanced Self-Respect

Independent Thinkers

Debaters respect themselves when they're able to construct and express their views – they don't feel nearly as validated when they're spoon-fed information. They tend to question everything boldly in their search for truth. Of course, trading thoughts constructively and fairly with others is a natural extension of how Debaters practice balanced self-respect. When they're receptive, they ensure that people want to hear their views, which in turn helps them see their worth. An open mind earns respect by the very fact that it offers it.

Such healthy expressions of intellectual independence may lead Debaters down the "road less traveled," introducing them to fresh perspectives and perhaps at times even revolutionary ideas. Finding a balance between pursuing their views and sharing truths back and forth with other people fosters self-respect. Rather than reinventing the wheel, Debaters roll along into new territory. When they exchange contributions with others and the world around them, their value becomes outwardly apparent – a welcome side effect.

Spirited Engagement

The best ideas remain only theory unless they're put into action, and Debaters are often ready for that next step. Enthusiasm doesn't always equate proficiency, though. People with the Debater personality type maintain balanced self-respect when they understand that accomplishments take time, and that developing valuable skills may be clumsy at first. They also know that's no reason to give up: Debaters have a keen ability to adapt to their environment, so they can get what they want from life. They find balance when they employ rational planning and patience, leaving them room to concurrently and deftly think on their feet.

When Debaters embrace balance among originality, vigorous action, and dedication, they're much more likely to reach their imaginative goals. They love to experiment, and the results can reflect the value of their effort, so their inspired intent doesn't always need a firm or specific goal to yield respectable results, either. When Debaters accomplish something, they affirm their creative energy, and that's something they respect deeply in themselves.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Extreme Defiance

An independent mentality can become destructive when Debaters act arrogantly or aggressively toward the world at large by constantly pushing their bold ideas – all too easy for this meddlesome type. Debaters who mistakenly conflate ego with self-respect may cast off the structure that supports their lives with the assumption they're above it all. When it begins to preclude anything outside their views, their self-respect becomes unbalanced, leading to brash reactions and disregard for otherwise reasonable boundaries.

When Debaters reject conformity to an extreme, they can easily conflict with everyday realities, harming their professional and personal lives. If something doesn't make sense to them, they may refuse to fall in line, brusquely going their own way. When they take these rebellious tendencies too far, such an adversarial stance can destroy many opportunities for changing the way people think through communication

and participation. This is far from the active, creative engagement that lets Debaters thrive, be happy, and respect themselves.

Abandoned Ideas

Enthusiastic minds don't always produce usable results. Debaters are thrilled to jump into new things, but they don't always maintain their focused drive; their attention can wane before they fully test a theory or finish a project. Despite energetic initial effort, Debaters often find the consistency and commitment required by their lofty pursuits boring – or find the next pursuit too distracting. Failure to recognize the value of a full process, start to finish, may pull them in too many directions, robbing them of success.

Over time, a mounting collection of unfinished projects, half-met commitments, and unrealized dreams can easily harm their sense of self-respect if they feel they have inadequate results to show for their efforts. Even if Debaters are happy following their inspired instincts into some degree of chaos, the outside world may not be forgiving of what might be seen as inconsistency or a lack of follow-through on important matters, resulting in missed opportunities or increased friction in both professional and personal arenas.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Seizing Useful Elements

To rebalance rambunctious independence that offers no practical advancement, Debaters must recognize that even if conformity is undesirable, there's value in participation. From a rational perspective, they can examine principles or conventions and utilize only the elements they appreciate. Balanced self-respect includes doing what's best for their growth, even if it requires a little self-control over their abundant energy while they figure out what works.

People compromise to get along in the world reasonably, and patient evaluation is a reasonable compromise Debaters can make before dismissing ideas entirely. In a sense, it's often just a matter of willing engagement and adaptation – both of which are Debater strengths. Adjusting their understanding falls well within Debaters' skill set as

well, and their curiosity can be a great motivator. Their independent, assertive spirit can lead to great things, but isolation due to excessive independence isn't so good. When Debaters feel like plowing over something, they can try the following:

- Consider it with an open mind. Sometimes the depth of a concept's value isn't apparent from the outside, and it would be a shame to miss out on a good opportunity. The best evaluation comes out of full immersion.
- Seek the benefit. Debaters are among the most energetically willing types – when they're in the mood. Finding the personal benefits of a convention they initially dismissed can rebalance an overly dismissive reaction.
- Take it apart mentally. The goal is rational analysis, but there's no commitment to maintain the structure of something while you check it out – the useful parts may be more apparent with some clever dissection.
- Improve the concept. Before steamrolling over something with a "superior" idea, determine whether it can be adapted and improved – often a quicker and far more efficient path to something better than starting from scratch.

Debaters can forge their path while still participating in the world. For them, self-respect comes from inspired practices and excellent outcomes, and there's no reason not to incorporate beneficial elements wherever they can find them. Even when they're going their own direction, they can still pick up some good things up along the way.

Focused on Finishing

When people with this personality type experience the power of creativity in enhancing their lives, they see the value of supplementing wide-ranging interests with some narrowed effort. Debaters rarely lack for energy, but they often must work to maintain focus – a worthy path of personal growth. Payoff is a key factor here, as rational minds recognize the importance of practical self-investment as a prerequisite for advancement. No one is better suited to creating their own success than Debaters, but to do so, they may have to identify – and stick to – some priorities in life.

The mere practice of dedication can be a source of healthy self-respect, regardless of the outcome. Naturally, people also derive much pride when the consistent effort they put forth offers an eventual reward. Even completing a small project can represent major growth, as the point is to practice consistency and achieve a goal. Here are some steps to practice follow-through:

- Pick a small idea to make life happier (for example, a relatively major, long-desired personal purchase).
- Decide on the scale and time involved. We suggest something that can be finished in about a month, but of course, some things have inherent limits. (The aforementioned example might require a savings plan over several months.)
- Start doing it immediately – delay serves little purpose. (In the example, start an "item fund" in a secure place.)
- Automate involvement as much as possible. Schedules requiring pure, focused willpower may not be ideal for Debaters, but a clever system that automatically elicits consistency is (for example, an automatic bank transfer every payday into the fund).
- Use calendar and/or reminder apps to stay on track. Remember, you are practicing the skill of consistent dedication; the project itself is just a vehicle.
- Tell close friends, family, and loved ones about the project. Their awareness and attention can serve as supporting motivation.
- Stick to the plan, focusing on the good things it will bring. (Won't it be great to have that new item?)

Debaters can practice true and ongoing focus by according themselves respect for whatever they accomplish. Self-respect can't be dependent on doing what others want, but it flourishes when Debaters proudly do what they know can help them make progress.

Self-Confidence

Flowing from the concepts of self-esteem and self-respect, self-confidence is the energy to maintain positive self-views in the face of the world's challenges and eventual setbacks in life. Self-confidence allows Debaters to move forward with their ideas and choices, using their energy wisely to be successful and happy.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Applying Rationality

People with this personality type affirm self-confident energy by actively using their ingenuity and sense of reason, with their creative minds serving as a source of motivation to persevere against challenges and achieve their goals. Debaters think that if it's rational, they can do it, and finding ways to implement their ideas in the world is the sure thing that drives them in life. Concepts and principles fuel them more than feelings, and their great willingness to put energy into the products of their imaginations is rewarded when the world recognizes their efforts.

When they also take this view toward their growth, Debaters can construct wise paths forward in their lives. They embrace new knowledge to reinforce their efforts, but they also take strength from knowing they can figure things out, and they're ready to understand whatever may come. Yet part of their energy comes from the fact that they don't need to think an idea to exhaustion before they take action. Debaters invest in motion, giving them self-confidence that isn't just energetic but also effective when applied in the world.

Engaged with the World

For Debaters, self-confidence isn't about certainty; it's about the lure of potential and the excitement of trying to do things – preferably not alone. Debaters aren't known for being resolute as much as vigorous. Their willingness to try things out, sometimes spontaneously, gives them great momentum in life, and it draws in others. Their tendency toward engagement can also drive personal growth, keeping them open to change and improvement.

Whether a social setting, work method, or entirely unfamiliar activity, Debaters initially find self-confident energy through imagination, but

then they easily shift into action, always interested to see where their efforts take them. Such curiosity can easily overcome personal limits or prejudices, and Debaters embody balanced self-confidence by openly seeking whatever the world has to offer.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Avoiding Emotion

Debaters' motivation may suffer in realms that exist outside of the rational. This isn't because they lack energy, but because they don't always see the point of putting effort toward areas of life where logic reveals little. Therefore, they may avoid situations they can't comprehend through some rational construct. Deep feelings and emotions sometimes seem of little importance to people with this personality type, and the reasons behind them don't always make immediate sense, defying Debaters' brisk, inquisitive, sometimes raw rationality.

Trying to grapple with such things in the world around them can eventually become tiresome, even to a personality type that enjoys engagement. When it seems that their mentality is ineffective, Debaters may become confused and daunted, especially when trying to deal with other people who don't seem to speak their language of logic. Realizing that they can't always predict the course of emotions can feel disheartening, and without restoring balance, they may simply dismiss such things, much to the chagrin of everyone around them.

Hewing at the Bramble Patch

Rebelliousness is virtually a watchword for Debaters. If their path is blocked by a metaphorical patch of thorns, they may very well take up mental machetes and hack away, excited to test their intellect. However, they sometimes rise to such challenges out of reflexive more than reflective intent, not necessarily applying their abilities to a helpful end. For them, mental challenges themselves may provide the appeal. However, even though they might blaze trails, emerging bloodied in unfamiliar places is hardly a rational use of power, or a reflection of balanced self-confidence.

One downside to strong momentum is that it doesn't necessarily require good direction, nor does it healthily self-correct in response to reasonable resistance. Willful Debaters can easily find themselves tangled in battles of dubious necessity or questionable personal benefit, solely because they want to triumph. Those who perpetually choose onslaught often find thorny opposition sprouting around them, and they may not find much time to enjoy life when they're lost in the weeds.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Emotional Experimentation

The solution to a lack of traction can sometimes be a headlong slide forward. Debaters can try an engaged approach when they're initially unable to get their head around seemingly irrational emotion. For a type who so wants to understand everything, just diving in can both leverage and maintain their energetic self-confidence. Avoidance doesn't generate answers nor personal growth, but Debaters can challenge themselves to understand the seeming vagaries of emotion from the inside out.

It's difficult for people with this personality type to accept that some factors are beyond their control and then move forward, but faltering self-confidence is often just the result of feeling as though they lack knowledge. Therefore, some direct, rational engagement with others can help Debaters rebalance a dismissive attitude toward emotion – and help them gain the information that gives them confidence. As an exercise in understanding emotion, Debaters can use their analytical abilities to practice it as a skill:

- Pick someone you know personally and whom you respect who seems to have an "emotional" nature.
- During regular contact (and perhaps by spending more time with them), observe their expressions of emotion.
- Analyze the mechanisms of what the person says or does to create a connection with others. Look for things like kind words to strangers, attentive listening to friends, or a sunny demeanor they willingly share with those around them.

- Try to internally answer the following questions.
  - Do they connect with others positively by using emotion?
  - Do they seem to feel rewarded by sharing emotion?
  - Do other people seem to enjoy the exchange?
  - How might you practice this beneficial behavior personally?
- Attempt to sincerely employ the skill with that same person. Reflect to them whatever it is they do to create positive emotional returns. (Use their methods – but your own words.)
- Observe the effects and note any improvements in communication and mood.
- Practice these steps with new people as well.

Debaters may not find the language of emotion to be their native tongue, but when they try to speak it using role models from their lives, they can come to respect, and perhaps even understand, its value in life. Emotional logic is a valid way of living, and its mechanisms have a very real effect on people's lives. When Debaters are willing to step in and try to understand emotion instead of avoiding or dismissing it as irrational, their self-confident energy can remain strong.

Picking a Beneficial Path

Debaters' enthusiastic yet prickly nature has the potential to endear them to others when they use their self-confident energy to be helpful. Debaters are wise to pick their battles, not out to fear but out of a thoughtful desire to achieve something genuinely worth their efforts. They can provide fruitfully from their work, but their personal resources are finite. Some thoughtfulness can help them overcome argumentative reactions, often leaving them more time to enjoy life instead.

One crucial way for Debaters to rebalance their use of energy is to turn their tenacious, inquisitive logic inward and determine what they truly want from life. The answers can be used as guidance for seeking happiness deliberately and wisely. In addition, Debaters can rebalance their tendency to get sidetracked in the fray by reconnecting with their original desire.

The best time to find a worthy path for self-confident energy is today, and Debaters can try the following:

- Narrow down a few personal skills or abilities that bring you happiness – anything from writing to working with children to practicing carpentry.
- Research ways each of your personal skills could be put to good use in the world, to create personal satisfaction as well as possible broader benefit.
- Figure out what's needed to develop and practice each pursuit (time, money, education, or maybe just a chance to get started?).
- Seek out local places, organizations, or venues where the skills could be used, such as a class, employment position, or volunteer opportunity.
- Ask to sit in and observe how others are already applying similar skills. Get some realistic information and feedback, then let the knowledge both temper and inspire your imagination.
- Think about which pursuit would provide the most happiness and excitement. Be sure to rationally consider all the information available and to listen to your heart.
- Having researched options, costs, and potential, decide to try one out – there's not much greater satisfaction than developing a skill that's enjoyable, and it may even turn into a lifelong joy.

Debaters can use their explorative vigor to follow a wisely chosen, joyful path, one where they won't stray into the overgrowth. Bypassing life's richer experiences for the sake of a fight is typically regrettable, especially when that same self-confident energy can be used to seek happiness and worthwhile growth.

Self-Evolution

Self-evolution is the idea that Debaters can turn their love of engagement toward improving themselves, constantly looking for ways to grow. It's important to note that self-evolution is about personal fulfillment – anything ranging from academic aspirations to something as soul-satisfying as learning to paint. The point of self-evolution isn't marching austerely toward a traditional goal, but rather daring to develop potential into reality.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Willing Evolution

Bold seekers of truth by nature, Debaters who want balanced intellectual growth are aware that they regularly need more information and insight at every stage of their lives. Their fertile imaginations keep the door propped open for new thinking about themselves as well as the world. More importantly, their rational logic requires them to recognize their mistaken perceptions, just as they strive against ignorance around them.

Self-evolution requires more than merely considering new perspectives. Debaters find balance by utilizing principles that were previously outside their intellectual capacity or knowledge base, amending their views, and then acting. Most rewarding is when they find opportunities to share such advancement with others, moderating the frustrations with the world around them. Passionate problem-solvers, Debaters vigorously seek to expand their capabilities to make life better, and they want to share that mission with other people.

Practical Learning

Given their brightly engaged manner, Debaters often successfully advance their minds by practicing their ideas in logical ways. Although exploring ideas is compelling and worthwhile, Debaters can avoid getting carried away by applying their creativity to the world around them in hands-on ways. Whether connecting with others for intellectual growth and exchange or experimenting on their own, Debaters balance their self-evolution by putting their boots on the ground in the real world.

People with this personality type are the source of many great ideas, and when they explore how the products of their thoughts can fit into reality, they experience a refreshed perspective that can update their thinking and touch off new ideas to pursue. Such efforts breed valuable feedback, serving as concrete points of balance for their inspired narratives and creative flow of thought. Nothing teaches better than experience, and active engagement is a balanced and exciting way Debaters can evolve.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

Mental Recycling

Debaters want to understand reality, but they sometimes become wedded to their ways, their openness to change clouded by the strength of their opinions. They may even reject good ideas merely because they're too different from their preferred practices. Without objective balance, mental elasticity and sharp insightfulness can be used to justify stale habits just as easily as new experiences. Although wide-eyed self-evolution has potential for expanding their understanding, intellectual repetition has potential for fostering ignorance.

Nowhere does this become more obvious than when people with this personality type refuse to constructively contribute to other people's initiatives and ideas. Debaters can easily pick apart methods, activities, and goals they don't like, choosing to question their validity before exploring them to form fair conclusions. Debaters may feel quite accomplished by dismissing practical opportunities unaligned with their existing views, not realizing they are among the greatest opportunities for growth.

Bullhorns and Banners

One of Debaters' most cherished abilities is their animated, creative communication style: They typically shine when speaking to an audience, and they often even enjoy it tremendously. However, excessively sharing their thoughts and knowledge can resemble overbearing, unbalanced monologues rather than engaged conversations. In the heat of the moment, Debaters can easily drown out others' voices, both literally and metaphorically, dispensing with their learned communication skills amid the thrill of broadcasting.

When they forget the value of bilateral connections with others, they miss out on the unexpected inspiration and support that people can offer through unique voices, collaborative ideas, and even thoughtful dissent. Intellectual and verbal vivacity is wonderful, but a self-important, unbalanced view of communication inhibits self-evolution and ultimately stifles growth.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Challenging Themselves with Change

For Debaters, practicing what they already know isn't the most effective path to self-evolution. Instead, the very definition of balanced self-evolution is tempering their reliance on their existing experience, then following their passion for progress and learning. People with this personality type can handle exposing themselves to contradictory or ambiguous practices in order to grow. Debaters' feisty mindset may tempt them to argue for what they hold dear, but personal growth comes from using that vigor to instead challenge themselves to try things.

Being willing to evolve their conclusions is a huge asset for Debaters, preventing missed opportunities and easing friction. They can decide to be ready to change when needed, building their knowledge from any source they can. Even less than successful endeavors provide information. Openness allows true wisdom to blossom, and Debaters can start by practicing positive change voluntarily:

- Instead of dismissing new views and ideas, decide to try them out. After all, gathering empirical evidence is necessary to either refute something or understand its benefits.
- Ask people who have new ideas for as much detail as possible. Employ constructive conversation rather than critical dissection.
- Ask for a demonstration of how they make these ideas work in their lives, then show positive appreciation for their efforts.
- Apply their approaches sincerely to test their usefulness. Keep in mind that they may end up being worthy, useful methods, so real effort is a wise investment in potential self-evolution.

- Give them more than one chance, and try them under different circumstances.
- Look for ways to hybridize and adapt others' ideas to make them personally suitable. Personal circumstances, needs, and skills differ – and it's not a contest; it's about searching for improvement.

For Debaters, experimentation can be an extremely fulfilling practice as well as a reliable way to spur self-evolution. Seeing and doing something for themselves not only satisfies their need for rational proof, but it also feeds their active sense of curiosity – an excellent way to evolve their sharp minds.

Hearing What Others Have to Say

If communication is a worthy effort, then comprehending what others are trying to express is the grand fruition of that effort. Learning information doesn't necessarily mean agreeing with it, but without deep understanding, a fair debate can never take place. Before Debaters argue or broadcast their opinions, they owe themselves and others the respect of truly listening. To do otherwise is to invite faulty decision-making, closing a great avenue for self-evolution.

Debaters often speak with wit; to listen as adeptly is a skill they can consciously improve. It may take patience to digest people's intentions, but Debaters can reap the rewards of honest give-and-take by making people feel valued. Asking others about what they know – and respecting their responses – can create a balanced cycle of exchange. Lively, fair conversation is a progenitor of wisdom that feeds Debaters' minds, perhaps even expanding their vocabulary of thought. A basic series of actions can help them practice receptive listening:

- Enter or start a conversation with gentle inquires – and a friendly smile.
- Ask questions and show interest in others' thoughts, validating them with honest attention.
- Give others all the time they need to share their thoughts by waiting to speak rather than interjecting. Silences, not pauses, are the green light.

- Listen carefully to what people say rather than risk becoming distracted as you formulate a response or relate a personal experience.
- If asked questions, try to give answers on the subject at hand that are useful. *Give* knowledge; don't just display it.
- Respond succinctly – don't hold the floor very long.
- Stay receptive by steering things back to questions and listening. It's OK to donate your own fair share of talk time.
- End exchanges with thoughtful positivity, even if not in agreement – "That's interesting. I'll have to think about that!"

Debaters have many opinions to share, but self-evolution requires balancing opinions with careful and respectful listening so that knowledge can flow in both directions. A dialogue, not a monologue, elicits the best from everyone. Their excellent mental flexibility lets Debaters find the value in other people's perspectives, and even a little such insight leads to better communication.

Self-Responsibility

This personal growth facet is about Debaters' decisions and what they value. People with this personality type are capable of great passion, whether caring for family, excelling at their jobs, or breathing life into creative projects. Consciously accepting ownership of all aspects of their objectives is key to personal growth; self-responsibility represents both accountability and capability in Debaters' lives.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Jurisdiction Over Life

Debaters have a gift for dissecting concepts and events, looking both backward and forward in time to see causes and probabilities surrounding almost anything. Blending that ability with self-responsibility gives them influence over the events in their lives, allowing them to choose how they respond. Debaters are perceptive, but it's not always possible to predict the future. People with this personality

type create balance when they use their abilities to adapt to whatever happens and still press forward responsibly with their goals. Balance, for Debaters, is about choosing to take responsibility for their fate.

This can mean different things depending on the situation, and it is more of an *attitude* of ownership than a specific course of action. For Debaters, self-responsibility means using knowledge and willpower to their greatest possible benefits and knowing that dwelling on negative reactions squanders precious time when happiness and success beckon. True greatness and personal growth are found not in the measure of ability – but in *how* ability is used. When Debaters accept accountability for their lives, they empower themselves to create a better future.

Courageous Acceptance

Debaters encounter upsetting situations and people, and acceptance isn't always easy for a personality type that so boisterously loves to argue. But even if it isn't easy, self-responsible Debaters rise to the challenge of moderating themselves. They balance their reactions to seemingly outrageous experiences by recognizing that self-responsibility allows them to choose *not* to engage, especially when progressive action isn't an option. This allows them to redirect their energy usefully instead; they can find loftier places for their passion than pointless conflicts.

Debaters may have to work harder than most to separate themselves from frustration, but such ongoing efforts lead them toward balanced self-responsibility. Constant agitation rarely brings happiness and success, and Debaters have better use for their heads than beating them against a wall. When they practice acceptance of circumstances, that can instead seek functional solutions. When they accept other people, they often find unexpected cooperation in applying their ideas to make their lives better.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Obsessed with Indictment

The fact that Debaters can see the workings of the world in complex detail is generally a virtue, but when they experience misfortune, their analytical tendencies can lead them into blameful dissection, tearing apart everything

that offends them. It's all too easy for such an expressive personality type to dispense criticism when incompetence or mental deficiencies seem so obvious. They may even come off as bullies. Yet they may not readily see their own need for personal accountability, nor take the self-responsible step of transmuting their ire into restorative action.

In fact, Debaters' tendency to express anger toward perceived inadequacy or failure often serves only to feed a vicious cycle of cynicism, even around legitimate complaints. Energy focused on outrage could be used productively, but when Debaters believe they're right and don't see any culpability in themselves, they may assume they don't have any responsibility to remedy the situation. This unbalanced, avoidant attitude can shift from positive capability into passive negativity, a state where they'll struggle to survive, much less thrive.

Destructive Intolerance

It's understandable to be frustrated: Their keen perceptions see the myriad problems in everyday reality. But attacking everything they see as "broken" is unbalanced – it's simply unrealistic to expect life to conform to their expectations, and holding such opinions can embitter them, a feeling they all too often project. When Debaters let their indignation get out of hand, they may find themselves in a state of anger, which prevents them from embracing opportunities for personal progress.

Allowing such attitudes to persist not only threatens Debaters' happiness and health but also can damage personal and professional relationships. Self-responsibility certainly involves speaking the truth, but Debaters may mistake that for the right to judge others. People with this personality type struggle to be accepting, often putting them at odds with people in their lives. Even if not directed at anyone they know, the force and harshness of Debaters' dissension can be so unpleasant as to disturb or even drive away those close to them.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Taking Responsibility for Their Lives

Blame is hardly an ideal way for these capable and creative types to use energy. Debaters can recognize the logical benefits of building

something better than blame when life lets them down. Instead, they can take responsibility – not only to adapt gracefully to circumstances but also to own up to their own involvement. There's great value in rooting out the cause of any problem, and once it's found, self-responsibility is a gesture of power because it claims an ability to effect change.

Self-responsibility also means learning from problems with an eye toward preventing them in the future. Debaters might accurately fault external causes for certain issues, but participating in a solution, even patiently mentoring those they previously criticized, is a far more satisfying and effective approach. Their energy and cleverness can certainly enable more productive action than mere finger-pointing. When something goes wrong in life, Debaters can use the following steps to help turn their minds toward progress instead of blame:

- Ask, "What happened?" Before assigning blame, seek answers with a cool, analytical mindset. The truth may come to light and provide a useful perspective.
    - Go over the chain of events to uncover the details of what happened. Ask others for their take on events.
    - Map things out on paper, if needed, including others' descriptions of events. Limiting the analysis to one perspective is almost certainly ignoring additional data.
    - If the root problem can be identified, see if it can be fixed. This is also a great time to seek the counsel of trusted, respected friends, family members, or colleagues.
- Be forgiving. Inanimate objects can't give apologies, and people can't undo history. Forgiveness benefits those who give it – stress and anger make life miserable, and they do real physical and mental harm. Calm patience is a rational investment in personal health.
- Move forward. Feelings of blame don't always go away quickly, but focusing on progressive action is helpful.
- Elevate others. Instead of pointing out how people are wrong, respectfully offer them mentorship – and be graceful if they decline.

The above steps are rational, but frankly, sometimes frustration and the desire to blame can be raw, so consider a classic but always helpful tool that any type can use to release emotion.

- Let it out. Write an unrestrained rant to the source of the problem and then read it aloud in private, letting out emotional energy along with the spoken words.
- Afterward, burn it – literally light it on fire or otherwise destroy it.
- If desired, do it all over again, start to finish. Let the acts of composing, expressing, and releasing negative thoughts and feelings create a sense of relief.
- Then move on to happiness and progress.

By examining how they can improve things instead of blaming themselves, others, or circumstances for their problems, Debaters can balance their sense of self-responsibility.

Being Accepting

Life presents nearly infinite opportunities to criticize. The world is full of flaws and flawed people, and tolerance and acceptance can seem like flimsy concepts to Debaters confronted by things they find offensive. However, practicing these virtues can rebalance frustration that produces no benefit and pushes others away. Debaters can do so by using one of their greatest strengths: inquisitiveness. They'll often find that their reactions are the source of their frustrations. Rational objectivity can reveal that harsh reactions aren't only unnecessary but also within their power to change. With Debaters' adaptability, such a mindset is within their reach.

This practice is about emotional self-control as well as logic, but its core is reason. Debaters can decide to embrace open curiosity, putting aside prejudice in favor of first-hand experience. Many things these imaginative people may rail against are conceptual or distant, with little direct bearing on their lives, but constantly doing intellectual battle may accomplish little to bring about happiness. Here's an exercise Debaters can use to practice tolerance. (It may require a little planning in advance.)

- Enter a social situation antithetical to your personal opinions, and decide to withhold judgment or thought. (For example, a progressive atheist could sit in the back of an orthodox religious service.)
- Quietly listen and absorb for 10–15 minutes (or longer if the subject proves interesting).
- Allow internal judgment (intolerance), but simply observe it instead of delving into it – collect the facts, not the feelings.
- If emotions like anger or frustration come up, feel them for five seconds, then refocus. It's important to respect and allow emotions, even while rebalancing them.
- Try and find the upside, even if it's not personally applicable. What are its positive points? How does it benefit people? Why do people like it, and how is that legitimate?
- Tally up the positives and negatives, then determine whether the positives make the situation more acceptable. Something needn't be enjoyed nor even engaged to be tolerated. If possible, meet up with a friend and discuss your observations out loud.
- Realize that the objectionable situation will always be there – but it's a matter of self-responsibility to focus on it or not.
- Keep this idea in mind every day: Where you place attention and energy is a personal choice.

There's no magic bullet available when Debaters perceive genuinely odious things. However, being right or telling others they're wrong isn't always enough to make life happy. Sometimes triumph lies in recognizing what can ultimately be a pyrrhic victory, as opposed to what can foster mutual understanding and progress.

Final Words

Choosing Elevation

When it comes to using their strengths, Debaters face a precipice. To put it simply, they tend to be forceful people, and purely following their instincts can cause them real problems. There's a fine line between brilliance and arrogance, between eloquence and bluster. Their tremendous potential just as easily applies to distinguished accomplishments – there's no personality type more capable of waging unconventional warfare against ignorance, obstruction, and villainy. Balanced self-respect and self-confidence can make Debaters magnanimous agents of good.

When they balance their instincts with the clarity of their intellect, Debaters retain their passion and imagination while exercising self-control and wisdom, enabling rational decisions and lofty aspirations to coexist. Leaping into such grand potential is essential to their happiness, and when they learn not to go over the edge – or step on others as they leap – their direction can be as admirable to others as it is thrilling for them. Consciously utilizing self-responsibility doesn't prevent Debaters from engaging in their passions in life, but it can help create positive outcomes.

Debaters may never come to admire certain aspects of life, but they always have the option to help themselves thrive within those constructs – or to build something better. When they accept the challenge of self-evolution, they may gain the wisdom and ability not only to prosper amid life's problems but also to overcome them. It feels great to hurdle over obstacles, be they external or internal, and once Debaters find their keys to success by growing past their personal limits, there's little that they can't do. When they excel to their standards, they and others tend to admire who they are learning to become.

The Paradoxical Extravert

Debaters lead a paradoxical existence. Although they are true Extraverts who want to engage with the world and the people in it, they struggle to connect either to the matters roiling their minds. Because of this tension, they often foist their imaginative thinking on unprepared or reluctant people – they engage with the world, but in their own idiosyncratic ways. Though Debaters want to connect to outside

ideas, their willingness to protect that connection can falter if it means compromising on a position or a belief. People with this personality type will bluntly and ferociously argue their points. Consider the time-tested question asked in self-help circles: "Would you rather be right, or would you rather be loved?" Debaters want both – but they often prioritize the first.

Debaters who keep and protect their own counsel in their paradoxical world have pronounced advantages. The gift of the Debater style is independence, and with independence come innovation and creativity. It takes a certain rebellious spirit to ignite the creative process, and Debaters have no trouble engaging in intellectual rebellion. They don't mind being the rebel, and it frees them to innovate.

Still, There's Balance

That said, Debaters may still decide that they can benefit from expanding themselves beyond their tendencies. They may find it effective to offset some of their bluntness with diplomacy. And maybe there are times to be right and times to be loved, each deserving a place in their lives as well as adequate attention to preserve both. Sometimes people are limited by the false dichotomies that they set up. Things don't have to be "either/or."

Although it's a common fear, Debaters won't lose their independence or blunt their mental acuity by growing emotionally. Living with more emotional intelligence is well within the reach of Debaters who wish to round out their lives. Meanwhile, they can still look at the world in their unique way and build compelling arguments for ideas that are refreshing and system-shaking. They can have and use both if they focus and apply effort. It's not about changing – it's about growing.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Debater Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Debater Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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